

The AI job title that came out of nowhere

Four years of US search demand across 1,053 AI job titles — v2, with forward deployed engineer

Alex Papageorgiou

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What this is

This is a second pass over the study in `report.pdf`, rerun with one title added to the universe: **forward deployed engineer**.

The v1 title list was filtered by an AI-signal regex — a title had to contain AI, LLM, agentic, prompt or similar to qualify. Forward Deployed AI Engineer passed. Bare Forward Deployed Engineer did not, because it names no AI technology at all. That is the title OpenAI, Anthropic, Palantir, Cohere, Mistral, Databricks, Ramp and Cursor actually hire under.

Adding it changed the answer.

The pull was also redone, so the window moves forward one month: **September 2022 – August 2026**, against v1's August 2022 – July 2026. That is a second difference from v1 and it is flagged wherever it moves a number.

The short version

One title now leads the entire field, and it was missing from v1. forward deployed engineer averages 18,100 searches a month over the trailing year and **38,033 over the last three months**. That makes it the largest AI career-intent term in the study, ahead of ai engineer (20,833) and prompt engineer (17,000). It is also the single largest net gain of any career term, and ranks **first by momentum out of all 289 modelable terms**.

It is a step change, not a trend. The title sat flat at roughly 400 searches a month for 29 months, then compounded about 30x between February 2025 and August 2026. Nothing else in the dataset has that shape at that scale.

v1 named the wrong successor. v1 concluded that context engineer had replaced prompt engineer. On the newer window, context engineer has itself peaked and is down 74% from its August 2025 high. The title that actually took the crown is forward deployed engineer.

The headline metric was hiding it. Keyword Planner reports a trailing 12-month average. For a title that stepped up mid-window that understates the current level by half — 18,100 reported against 38,033 actual. Any ranking built on the reported average gets this wrong.

Most AI job titles are already past their peak. Of the 16 largest career terms, only forward deployed engineer and ai engineer are within 15% of their own best month. Ten of them have lost more than half their search demand.

Where the data comes from

Google Ads Keyword Planner API, United States, September 2022 through August 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20, in a single get_volumes request covering 1,052 unique keywords.

Stage	v1	v2
Titles in the master list	1,052	1,053
Unique after normalisation	1,051	1,052
Returned by the API	1,048	1,049
With any search volume	390	394
After collapsing identical series and zero-volume rows	379	381
Modelable (peak above 20 searches/month)	283	289
— career intent	254	260
— tool intent	29	29

The v2 universe is one title larger, but **six** more terms clear the modelling threshold. forward deployed engineer is one; the other five —llmops engineer, ai compliance specialist, ai frontend engineer, ai drug discovery scientist and clinical ai reviewer — crossed the 20-searches/month floor on the newer window. Nothing that was modelable in v1 dropped out.

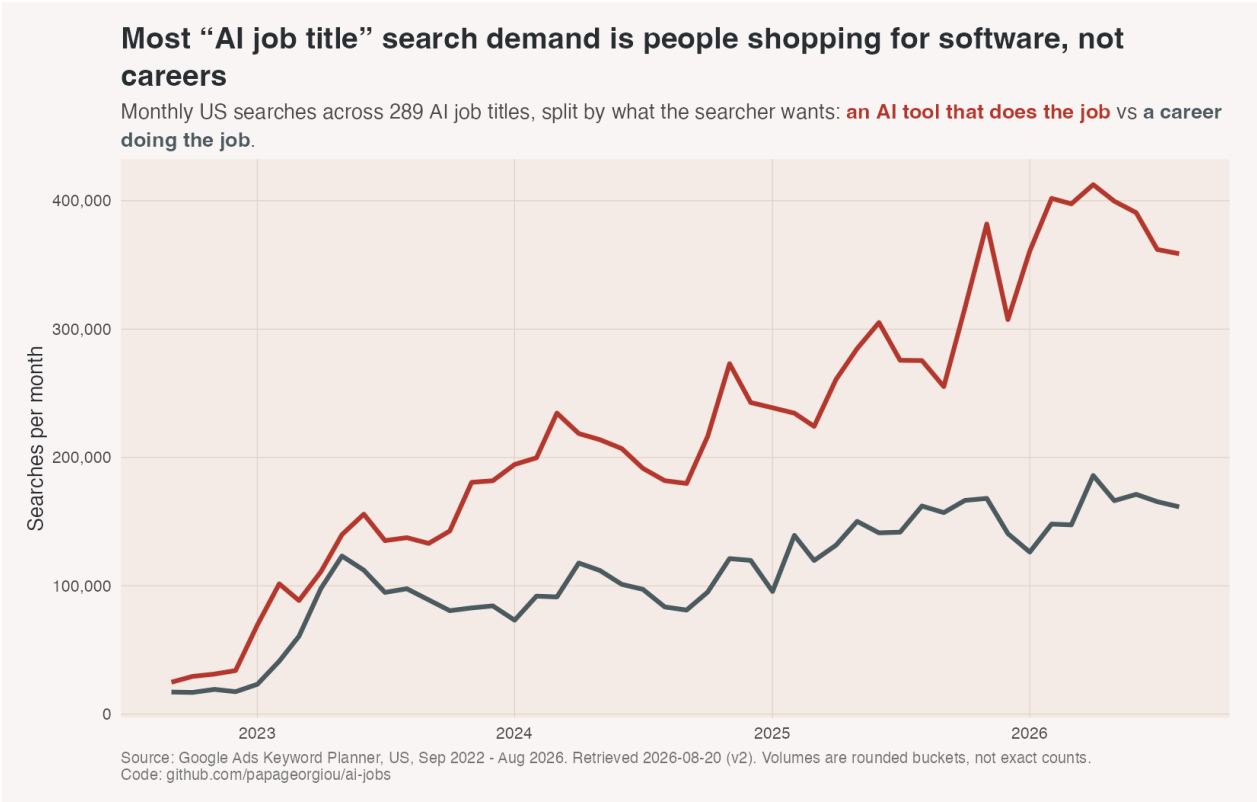
i Note

Keyword Planner reports **rounded buckets** (720, 880, 1,000, 1,300...), not exact counts, and reported volume can be inflated by bot or AI-driven traffic. Every figure here is an order of magnitude with a direction, not a precise measurement.

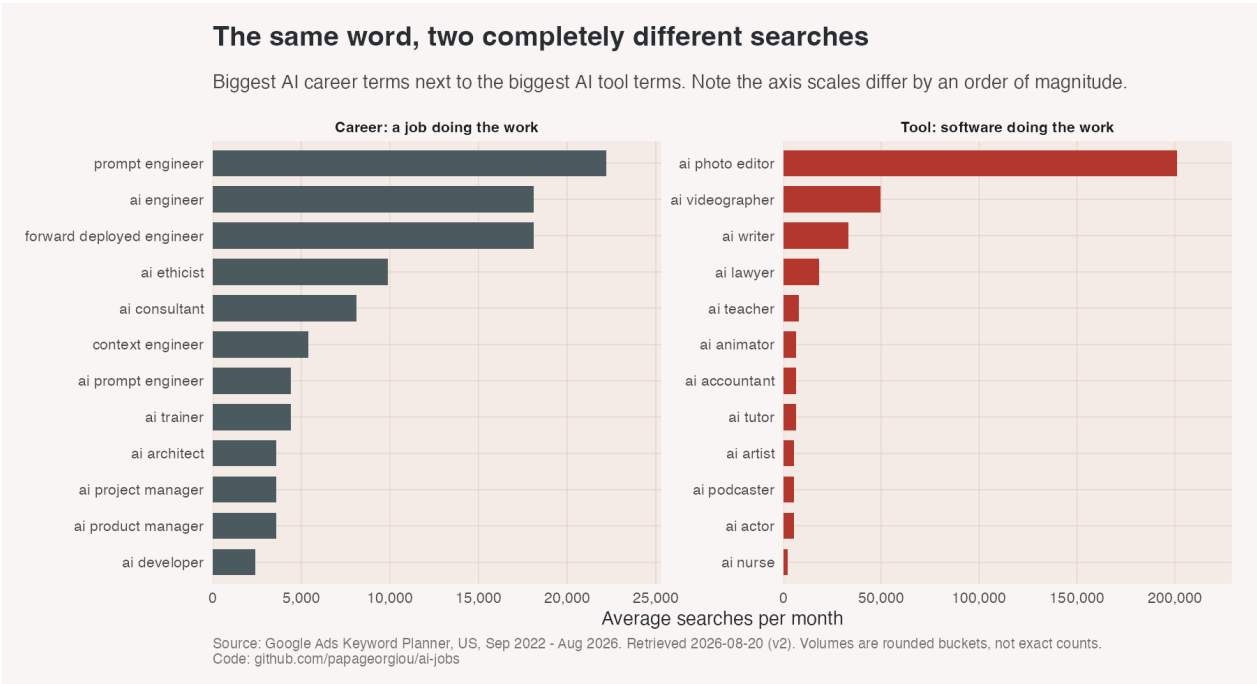
Finding 1: the software-versus-career split still dominates

The v1 headline holds. Terms like ai photo editor (201,000/month) and ai lawyer (18,100/month) are people shopping for software, not researching a career, and they carry most of the volume.

29 tool-intent terms carry 358,290 searches a month. The 260 career terms carry 157,330 — **69.5%** of all volume is tool intent, against 71.0% in v1.



The share moved for two reasons that pull in the same direction: forward deployed engineer added 18,100 to the career side, and prompt engineer lost 4,900 from it.

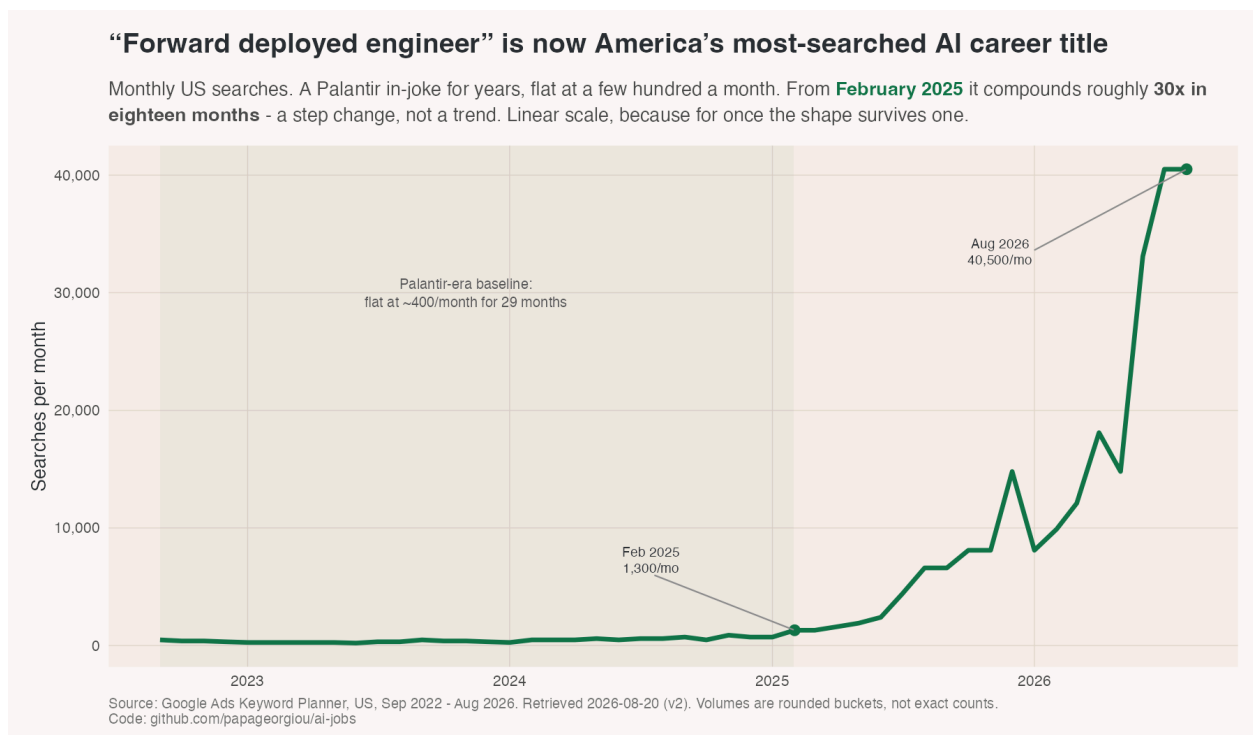


Everything from here on is career-intent terms only.

Finding 2: forward deployed engineer

This is the finding that v1 could not have produced.

Trailing 12-month average	18,100/month
Last three months (Jun–Aug 2026)	38,033/month
Latest month (Aug 2026)	40,500/month
Growth, first 12 months vs last 12	+5,656%
Net searches/month gained	+17,581 (largest of any career term)
Momentum rank	1st of 289



The shape is the point. From September 2022 to January 2025 the series is flat between 210 and 880 searches a month — the Palantir-era baseline, a job title that existed but that almost nobody looked up. From February 2025 it climbs without a meaningful pause: 1,300 in February 2025, 6,600 by August, 14,800 by December, 33,100 by June 2026, 40,500 in July and August.

That is roughly a **30x increase in eighteen months**, and it is still at its high in the last month of data.

The linear trend fit is deliberately reported as poor — R^2 of 0.49 on the rolling average. That is not a weakness in the signal, it is a statement about its shape: this is a step change with an exponential ramp, and a straight line is the wrong model for it. The same caveat applied to context engineer in v1.

Why the title is plausible on its own terms

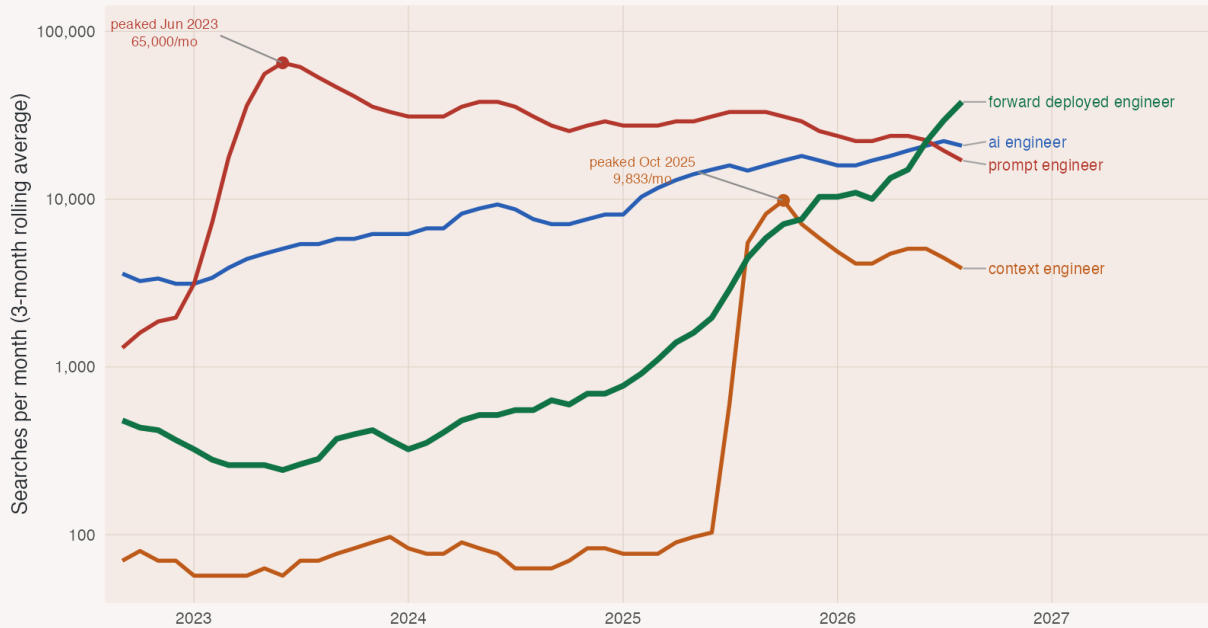
forward deployed engineer is a Palantir coinage for an engineer embedded with a customer. It stayed a Palantir-specific term for a decade. Through 2025 the AI labs adopted it wholesale for the role of embedding engineers inside enterprise accounts to make model deployments actually work. The search curve tracks that adoption, not a product launch — which is why it compounds over eighteen months rather than spiking in one.

Finding 3: prompt engineer has now been replaced twice

v1’s Finding 2 was that prompt engineer peaked and context engineer replaced it. The first half is more true than ever. The second half did not survive the extra month of data.

“Prompt engineer” has now been replaced twice

Prompt engineer peaked mid-2023 and is down 77%. **Context engineer** - the successor v1 identified - peaked in late 2025 and is already down 74%. **Forward deployed engineer** passed both and is still at its high, while **AI engineer** just kept climbing. Peak markers sit on the 3-month rolling average, so they lag the raw monthly high. Log scale.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner, US, Sep 2022 - Aug 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20 (v2). Volumes are rounded buckets, not exact counts.
Code: github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs

Title	Peak	Last 3 months	Off peak
prompt engineer	74,000 (May 2023)	17,000	−77%
context engineer	14,800 (Aug 2025)	3,867	−74%
ai engineer	22,200 (May 2026)	20,833	−6%
forward deployed engineer	40,500 (Jul 2026)	38,033	−6%

prompt engineer did not merely plateau. On the v1 window its first-year-to-last-year change was −4%, which reads as flat. One month later it is −22%, and its trailing average fell from 27,100 to 22,200 — the largest single move of any term between the two runs. The decline is now unambiguous.

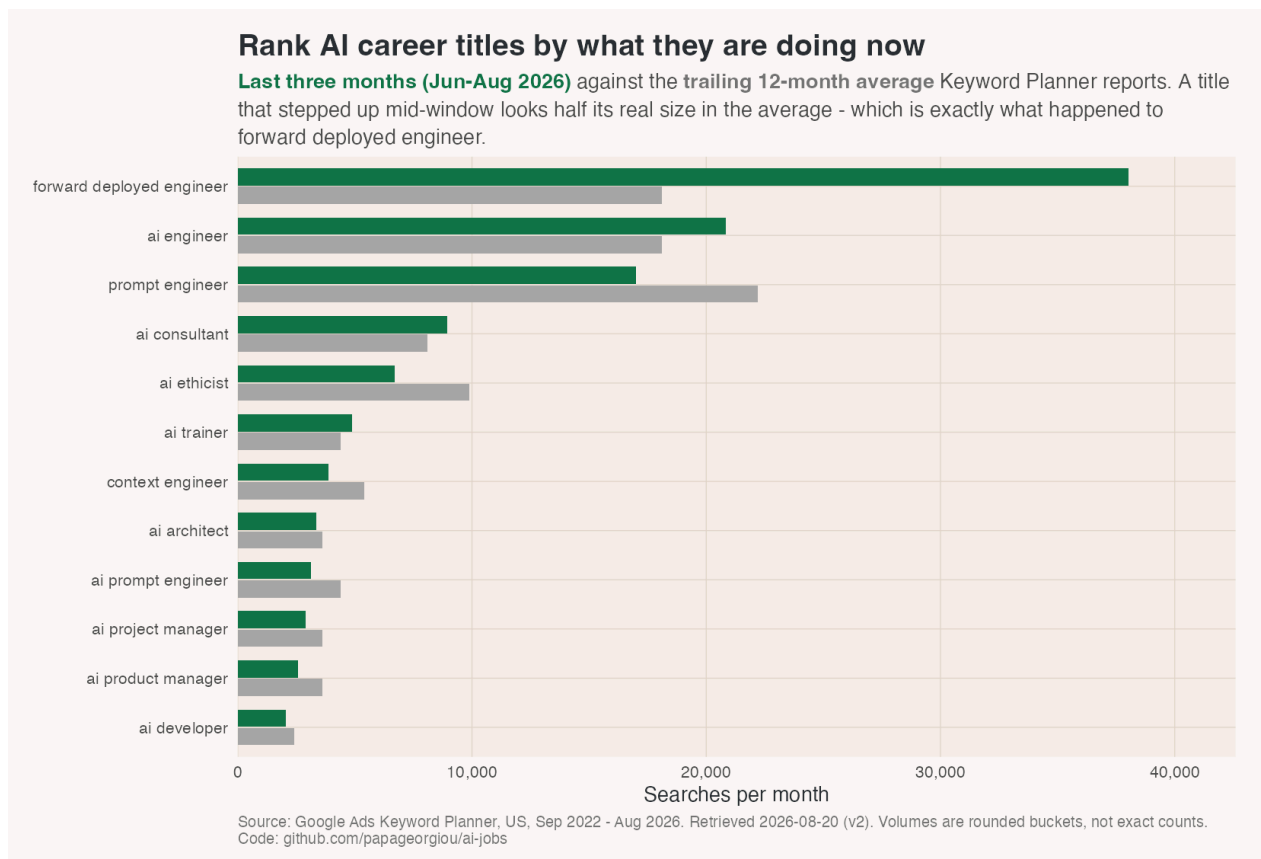
context engineer was v1’s standout: 96x growth, near the top of both the growth-rate and net-gain rankings. It is still the fastest-growing term in v2 by percentage (+7,656%), but it peaked in August 2025 and has given back three quarters of it. v1 read an adoption spike as a succession. It was a spike.

ai engineer remains the quiet story — no spike, no collapse, at 96% of its all-time high.

Finding 4: the reported average is the wrong ranking metric

This is a methodological finding, and it generalises past this dataset.

Keyword Planner’s avg_monthly_searches is a **trailing 12-month mean**. For a title whose level is stable that is a fine summary. For a title that stepped up mid-window it is roughly the midpoint of the step, which is not a number that describes any actual month.



forward deployed engineer reports 18,100 and is running at 38,033 — the reported figure is **47% of the real current level**. The error runs the other way for declining titles: ai ethicist reports 9,900 and is running at 6,700.

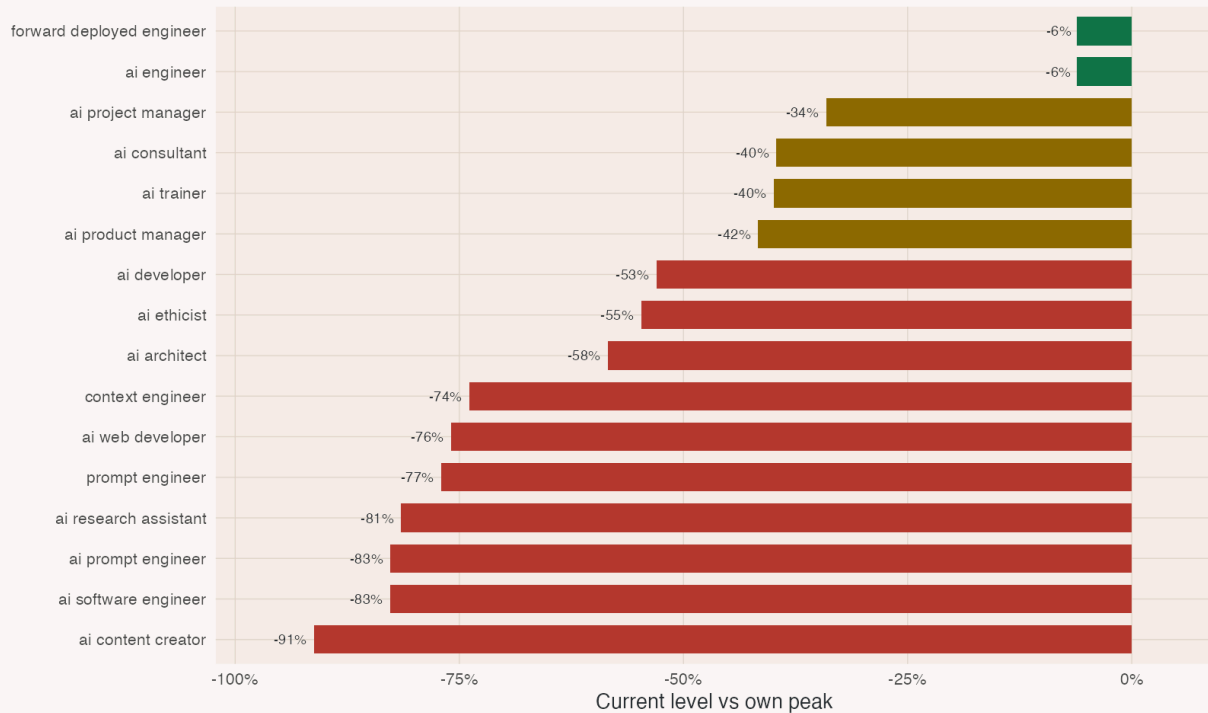
Ranked on the reported average, prompt engineer leads at 22,200, with forward deployed engineer and ai engineer tied behind it at 18,100. Ranked on the last three months the order inverts completely: forward deployed engineer (38,033), ai engineer (20,833), prompt engineer (17,000). v1 ranked on the average throughout, which is a reasonable default and was the right call for a set of mostly stable series. It stops being the right call once a step-change term is in the universe.

Finding 5: most AI job titles are already past their peak

Setting each title against its own best month, rather than against each other, produces a picture that neither v1 nor the growth rankings show.

Most AI job titles are already past their peak

Last three months against each title's own best month in the four-year window. **Green** is still at its high; **red** has lost more than half its search demand. Career-intent terms averaging 800+/month recently.



Of the 16 career terms in the chart, two are within 15% of their peak — forward deployed engineer and ai engineer. Four are 30–45% off. **Ten have lost more than half their search demand**, including prompt engineer (–77%), ai prompt engineer (–83%), ai software engineer (–83%) and ai content creator (–91%).

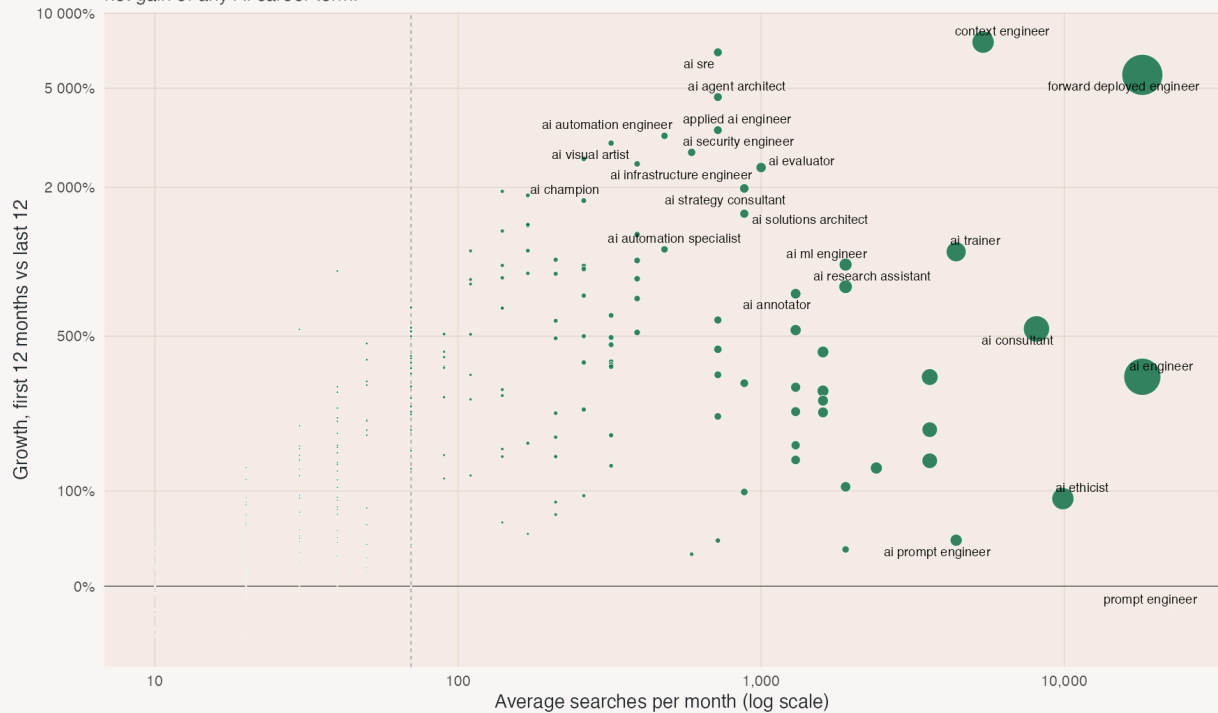
The AI job-title vocabulary turns over fast. Most of what was worth writing about in 2023 is in decline as a search term, and the growth is concentrated in a very small number of names.

Finding 6: growth rate and net volume still disagree — with one exception

v1's Finding 3 was that percentage growth and absolute gain rank nearly disjoint sets of titles. That remains true, and it remains the reason to report both.

Small and exploding, or big and steady - with one exception

Every AI career search term. Horizontal = how much it is searched; vertical = growth from the first year to the last. Bubble size = searches per month gained. **Forward deployed engineer** is the biggest bubble on the chart: joint-largest by volume *and* the largest net gain of any AI career term.

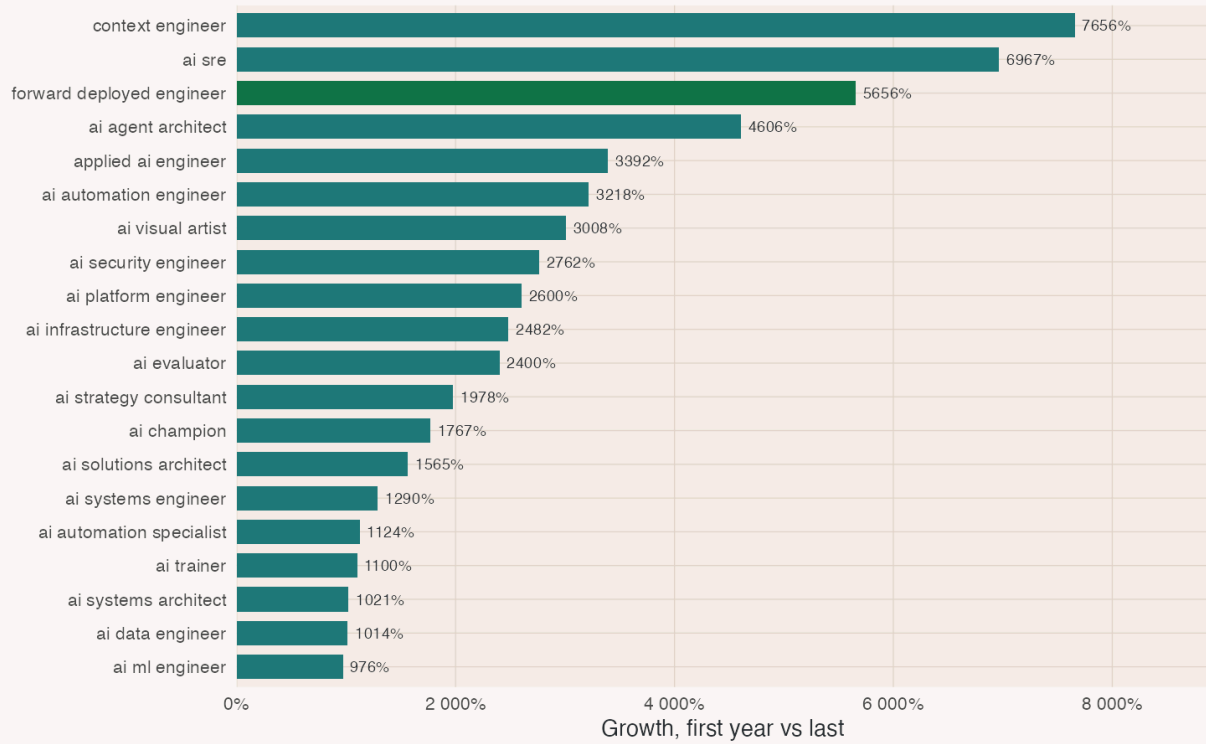


Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner, US, Sep 2022 - Aug 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20 (v2). Volumes are rounded buckets, not exact counts.
Code: github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs

Ranked by **percentage growth**, the top is still titles that barely existed in 2022, most of them under 1,000 searches a month:

The fastest-growing AI job searches are roles that did not exist in 2022

Growth from the first 12 months to the last. Restricted to terms averaging 200+ searches/month, so rounding noise cannot top the chart.



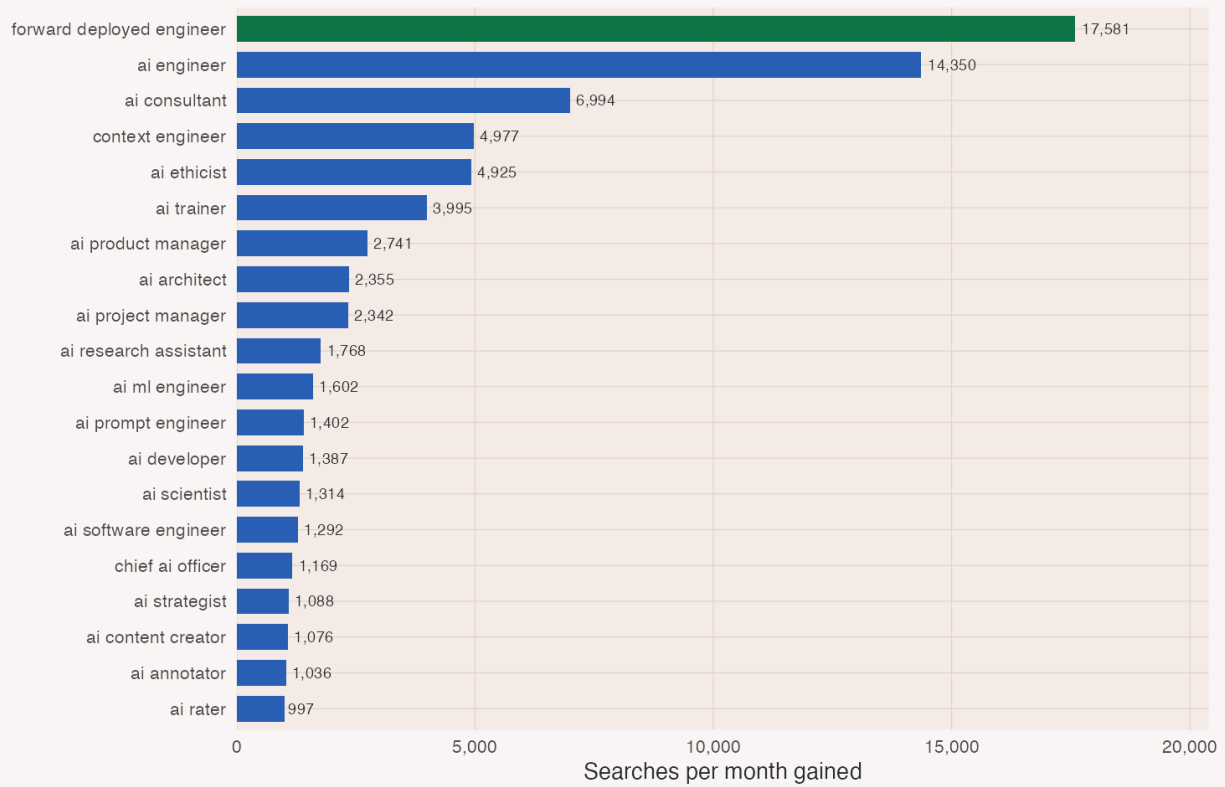
Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner, US, Sep 2022 - Aug 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20 (v2). Volumes are rounded buckets, not exact.
Code: github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs

Ranked by **searches actually gained**:

Title	Searches/mo gained	Growth
forward deployed engineer	+17,581	+5,656%
ai engineer	+14,350	+340%
ai consultant	+6,994	+540%
context engineer	+4,977	+7,656%
ai ethicist	+4,925	+90%
ai trainer	+3,995	+1,100%

Ranked by searches actually gained, one title dwarfs the rest

Absolute monthly searches added between the first and last year of the window. Percentage growth flatters tiny terms; this does not.

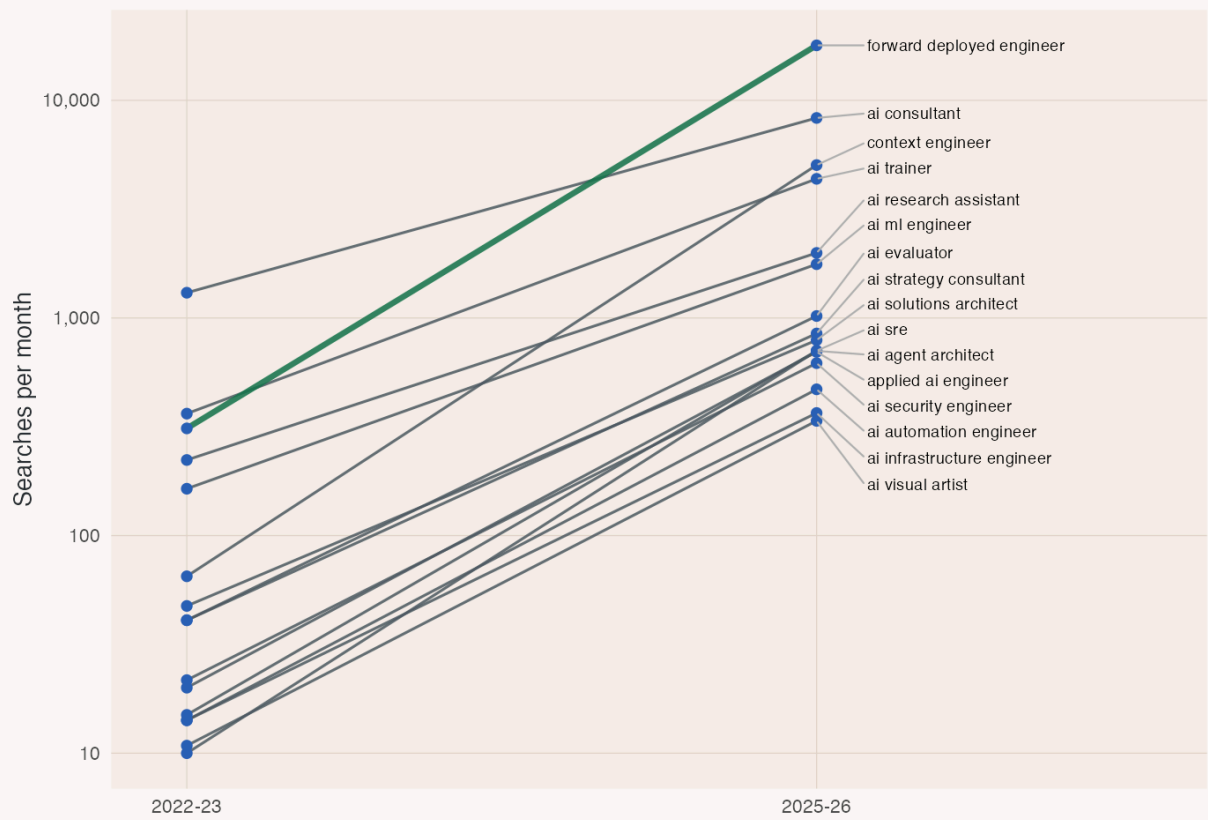


Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner, US, Sep 2022 - Aug 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20 (v2). Volumes are rounded buckets, not exact.
Code: github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs

forward deployed engineer is the exception the v1 data did not contain: **first by net gain and third by growth rate** (among terms averaging 200+ a month), while sitting at the top of the volume distribution. In v1 only context engineer came close to that combination, at a fifth of the volume — and it has since turned over.

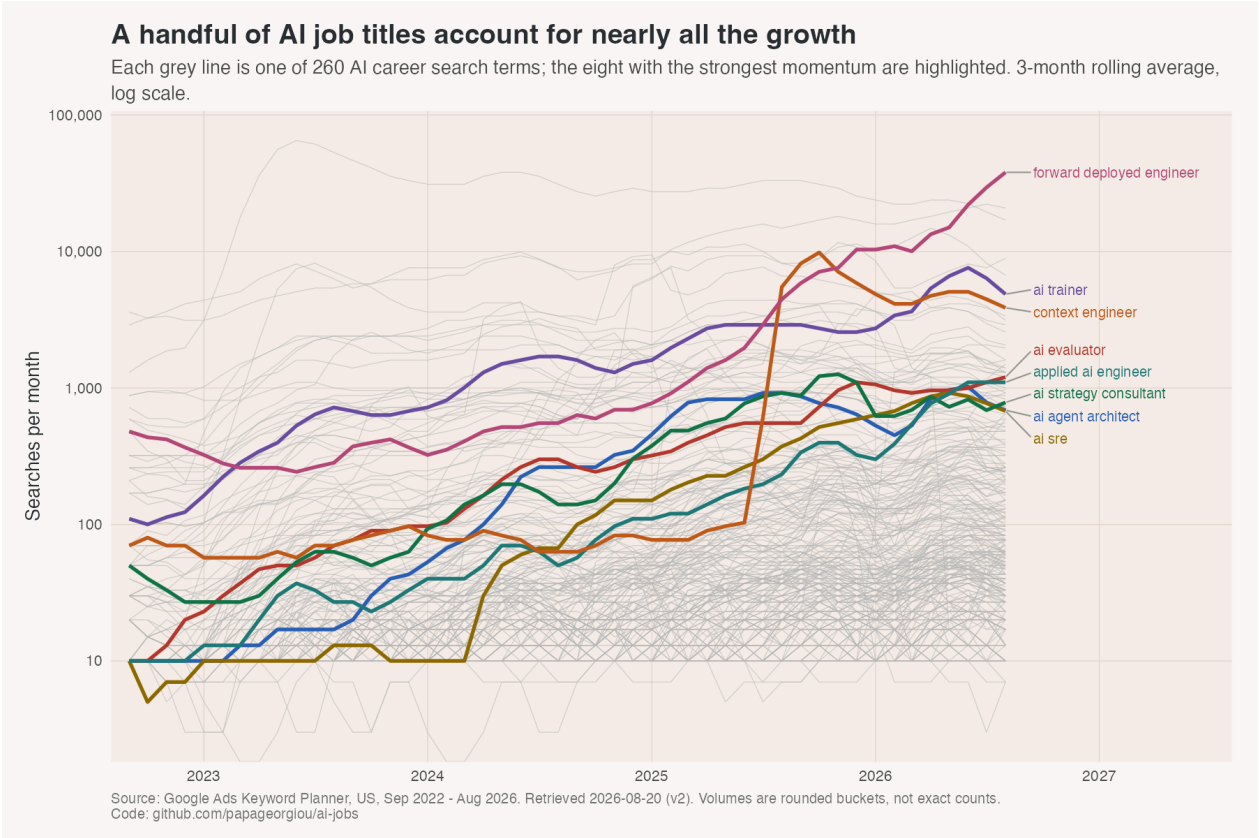
Four years of movement in the AI titles with the strongest momentum

Average monthly searches in the first year of the window vs the last. Log scale.

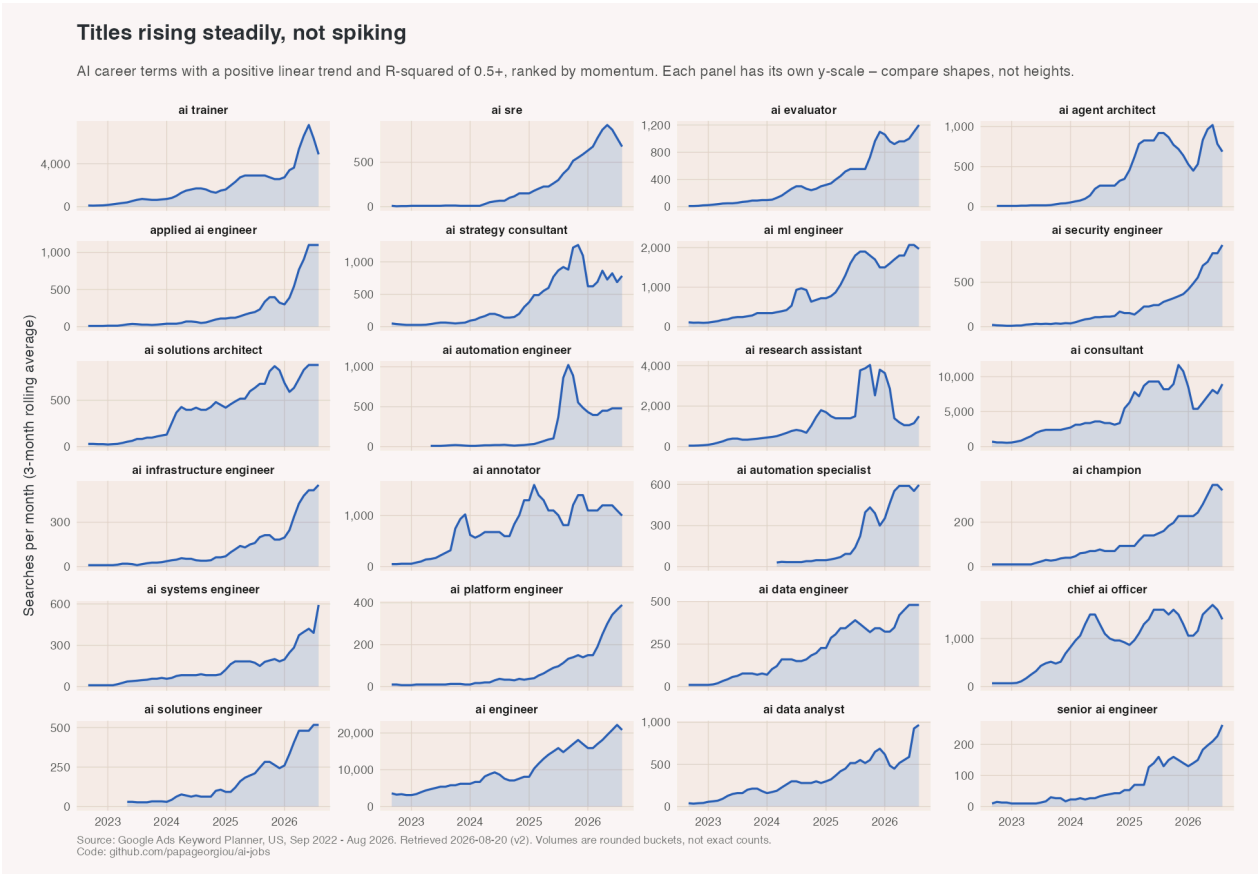


Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner, US, Sep 2022 - Aug 2026. Retrieved 2026-08-20 (v2). Volumes are rounded buckets, not exact counts.
Code: github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs

Finding 7: the whole field, and the clusters



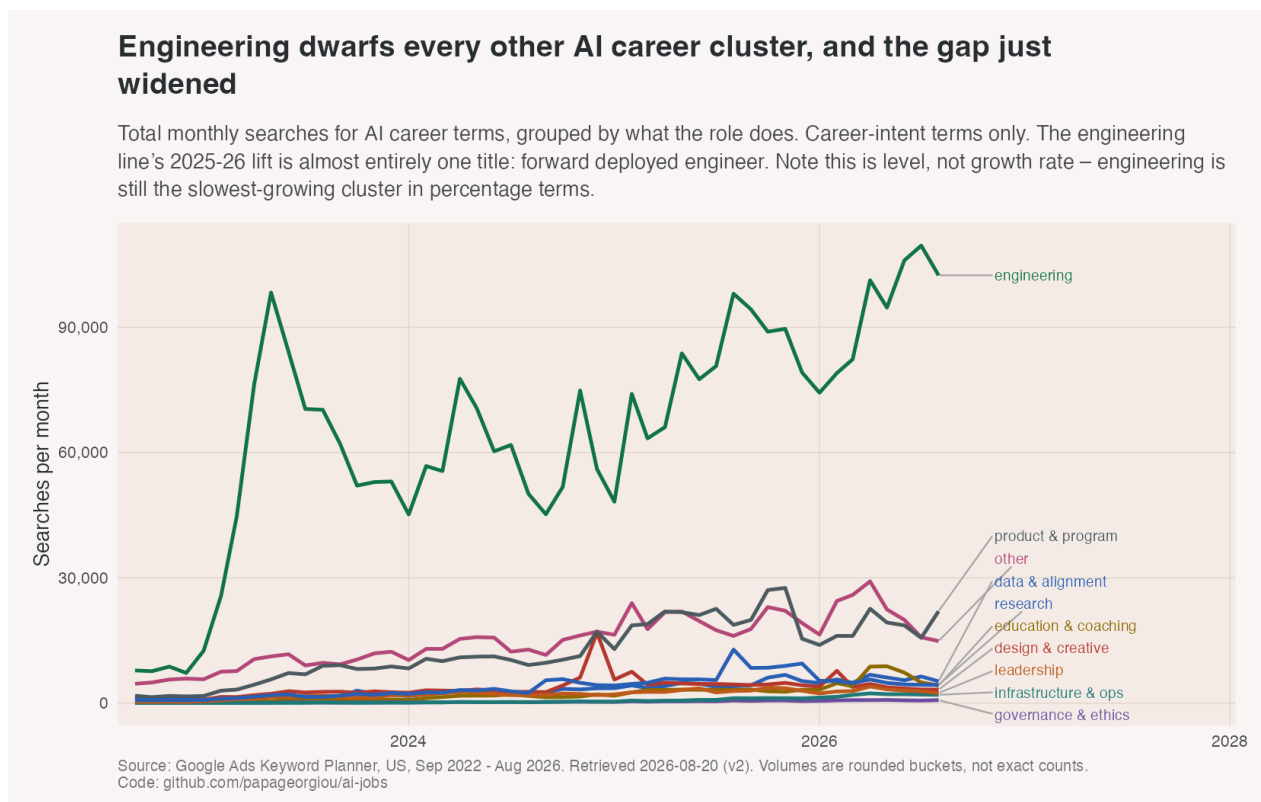
Log scale, because the biggest career terms sit in the tens of thousands while the emerging ones sit in the hundreds.



Career-intent volume grouped by what the role actually does:

Function	Terms	Searches/mo	Gained	Growth
engineering	78	90,790	+48,958	+114%
other	67	20,560	+13,066	+166%
product & program	22	19,650	+15,551	+390%
research	14	5,990	+5,000	+411%
data & alignment	10	5,770	+4,384	+342%
education & coaching	8	4,910	+4,451	+1,097%
design & creative	22	4,350	+2,792	+181%
leadership	12	2,920	+2,177	+240%
infrastructure & ops	11	1,750	+1,614	+1,957%
governance & ethics	16	640	+535	+440%

Gained and Growth are both computed on the summed cluster series, first 12 months against last 12 – not as a sum of the per-title figures, which drop leading zero months individually and so total slightly lower.

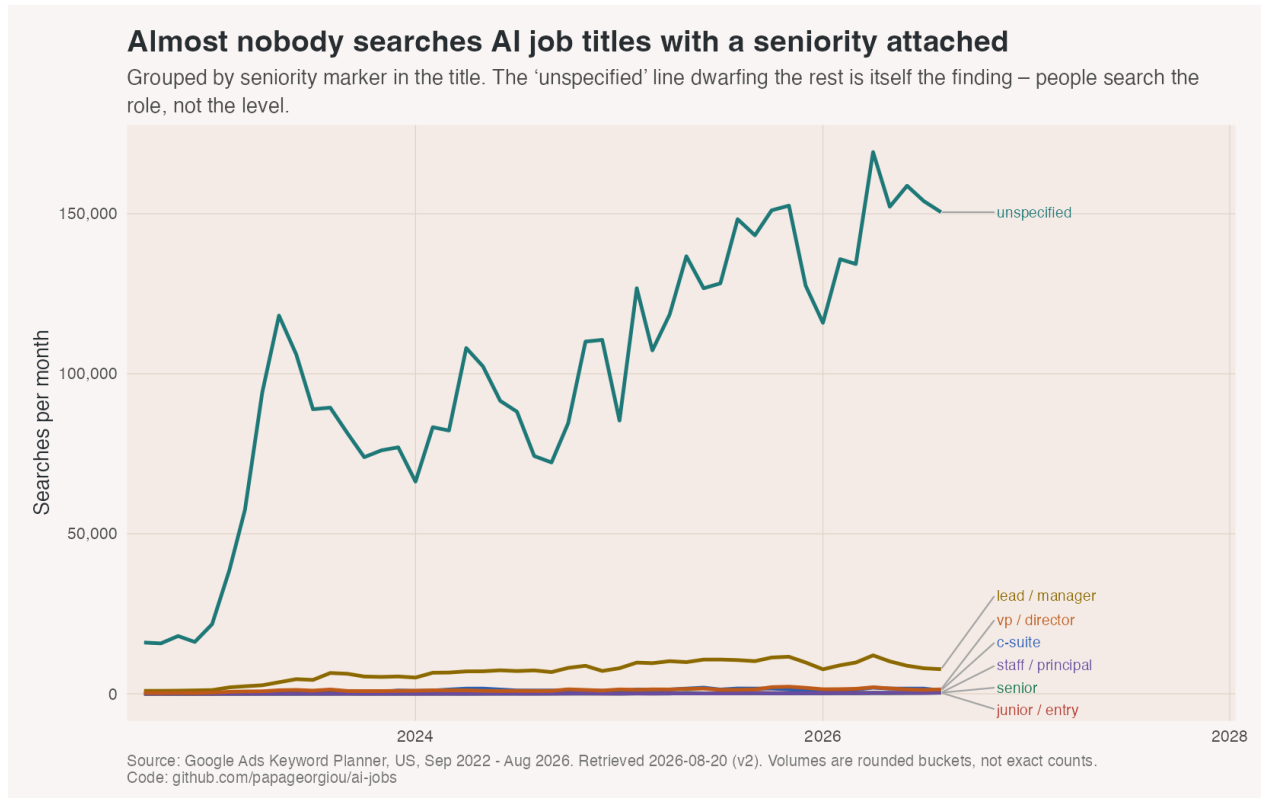


Engineering's lead widened, and it is one title. The cluster's net gain goes from +39,159 in v1 to +48,958 in v2 – more than three times the next cluster. Almost all of that delta is forward deployed engineer.

Engineering is still the slowest-growing cluster in percentage terms. +114% first year against last, last of the ten. Level and rate genuinely disagree here, and v1's conclusion – that engineering is not where the *fastest* growth is – survives v2 intact. What changed is that engineering is now pulling further ahead in absolute searches while still growing slowest in relative terms.

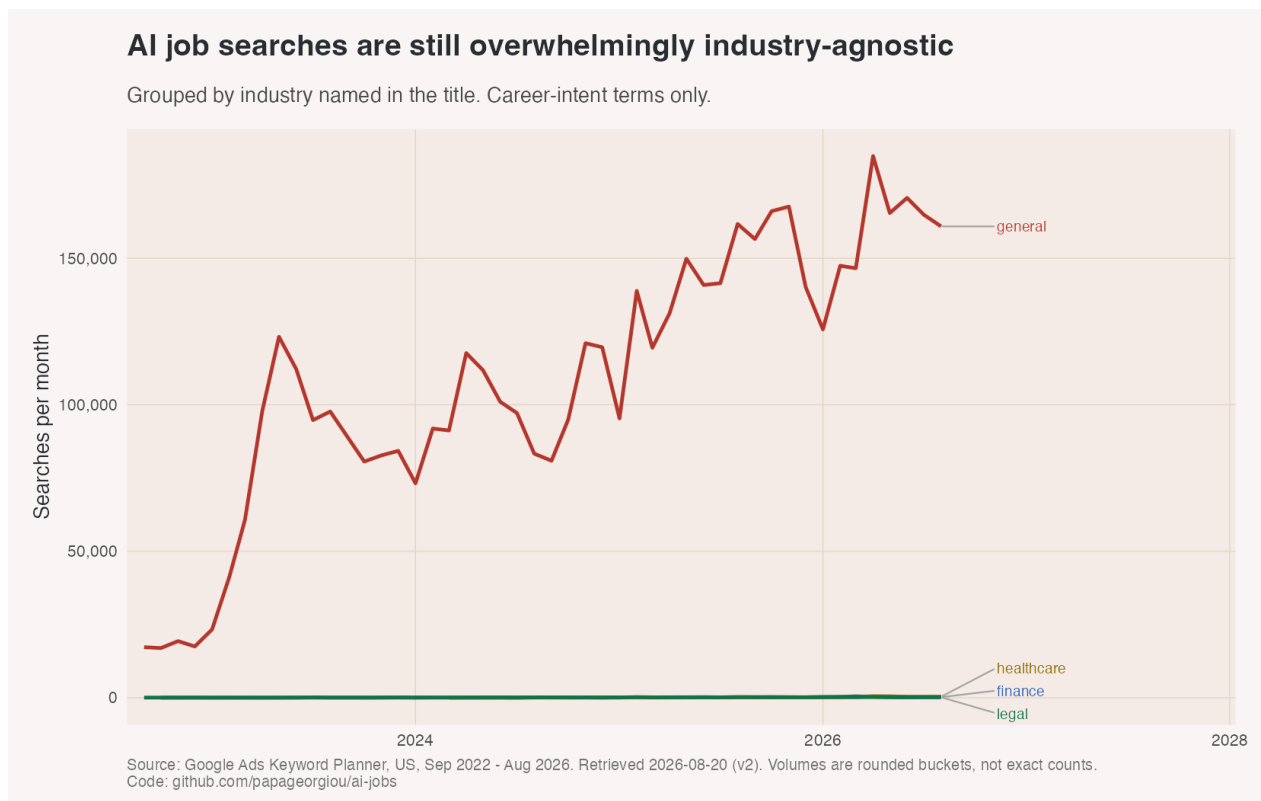
Governance and ethics is still remarkably small. 16 titles, 640 searches a month between them. As in v1, ai ethicist (9,900/month) sits in the other bucket, which understates this cluster badly – see caveats.

Nobody searches for a seniority level



208 of 260 career terms carry no seniority marker, and they account for essentially all the volume. forward deployed engineer is itself an example – nobody searches senior forward deployed engineer.

And almost nobody searches by industry



274 of 289 terms are industry-agnostic.

What changed between v1 and v2

	v1	v2
Window	Aug 2022 – Jul 2026	Sep 2022 – Aug 2026
Titles	1,052	1,053
Modelable terms	283	289
Tool-intent share of volume	71.0%	69.5%
Largest career term (avg)	prompt engineer, 27,100	prompt engineer, 22,200
Largest career term (last 3mo)	—	forward deployed engineer, 38,033
Top term by momentum	context engineer	forward deployed engineer
Largest net gain	ai engineer, +14,283	forward deployed engineer, +17,581
The prompt-engineer successor	context engineer	context engineer, then FDE
prompt engineer, first yr vs last	–4%	–22%

Only 45 of the 283 shared keywords changed their reported average at all between the two pulls, and most moves were one rounding bucket. The material ones were prompt engineer (–4,900), context engineer (–1,200), ai podcaster (–1,200) and ai architect (–800) — all declines, all consistent with the one-month window shift catching more of a downturn.

Conclusions that survived v1 unchanged: the tool-versus-career split and its size; the peak and decline of prompt engineer; the steady non-spiking rise of ai engineer; the seniority and industry findings; the disagreement between growth rate and net volume; the small size of governance and ethics; that roughly two-thirds of circulating AI job titles have no measurable search demand.

Conclusions that changed: which title leads the field; which title succeeded prompt engineer; whether any title is simultaneously large, fast-growing and high-gaining; and whether the reported 12-month average is a safe ranking metric.

Caveats worth stating

- **Reported volume is not ground truth.** Rounded buckets, and inflatable by non-human traffic.
- **forward deployed engineer is flagged by the spike detector** (ratio 68.6 against its own median, flagged month July 2026), and it is worth being explicit about why it is kept. The detector compares the maximum against the median of the whole 48-month series, so any genuine step change scores high — the median here is dominated by the 29 flat baseline months. The distinguishing evidence is duration: this is eighteen consecutive months of increase, not one anomalous month, and the last three months are all at the top. A bot or scraping artifact does not usually hold a plateau for a quarter. context engineer was flagged on the same logic in v1 and judged genuine on the same grounds — and note that it subsequently reverted, which is the outcome this caveat exists to allow for.
- **Two things changed between v1 and v2**, not one. The added title is the intended change; the one-month window shift is a side effect of re-pulling. Where a number moved, the “What changed” section says which cause is responsible.
- **The tool-versus-career split is a judgement call**, applied by rule against a list of professions AI performs as a service. ai trainer and ai architect are deliberately kept as careers despite matching the pattern. forward deployed engineer does not match the ai <profession> shape at all, so it is classified as career intent without a judgement call being needed.

- **ai ethicist (9,900/month) still falls into the other function bucket** rather than governance and ethics, which understates that cluster in the table above. Unchanged from v1 and still not hand-patched.
 - **Only the bare title was added.** Forward Deployed Software Engineer and Forward Deployed Machine Learning Engineer are in circulation and were deliberately left out, to keep v2 comparable to v1 at one changed input. The true demand for the role family is therefore somewhat higher than the figures here.
 - **73 non-seasonal spikes were flagged**, against 76 in v1.
-

Method

Full pipeline and data at github.com/papageorgiou/ai-jobs. v1 artifacts are in `output/` and v2 in `output_v2/`; both are reproducible, and v1 is unmodified.

Volumes pulled via the Google Ads Keyword Planner API in a single `get_volumes` request (1,052 keywords, US, English). Series are 48 months. Growth is measured by comparing the mean of the last 12 months against the mean of the first 12, which is robust to seasonality; momentum averages the percentile ranks of proportional and absolute growth so that a fast-growing niche term and a large steady one can be compared on one scale. Trends are OLS fits on a 3-month rolling average. Clusters are rule-based on the title text across three independent axes.

The v2 run differs from v1 only in its input list and its retrieval date. Every script from `00_prep_keywords.py` through `03_cluster.py` is the same file, run with `OUTPUT_DIR` and `MASTER_CSV` pointed at the v2 artifacts. Charts are a separate script, `04_charts_v2.R`, because several v1 chart *conclusions* no longer hold and rewriting them in place would have broken v1's reproducibility.